by sneezes and coughs. By her own account, she was motivated to support me out of loyalty to her conscience more than to the ideological demands of her employer. Certainly her politics seemed shaped less by Assange's feral opposition to central power than by her own conviction that too much of what passed for contemporary journalism served government interests rather than challenged them. As we hurtled to the airport, as we checked in, as we cleared passport control for the first of what should have been three flights, I kept waiting for her to ask me for something—anything, even just for me to make a statement on Assange's, or the organization's, behalf. But she never did, although she did cheerfully share her opinion that I was a fool for trusting media conglomerates to fairly guard the gate between the public and the truth. For that instance of straight talk, and for many others, I'll always admire Sarah's honesty.

We were traveling to Quito, Ecuador, via Moscow via Havana via Caracas for a simple reason: it was the only safe route available. There were no direct flights to Quito from Hong Kong, and all of the other connecting flights traveled through US airspace. While I was concerned about the massive layover in Russia—we'd have almost twenty hours before the Havana flight departed—my primary fear was actually the next leg of the journey, because traveling from Russia to Cuba meant passing through NATO airspace. I didn't particularly relish flying over a country like Poland, which during my lifetime has done everything to please the US government, including hosting CIA black sites where my former IC colleagues subjected prisoners to "enhanced interrogations," another Bush-era euphemism for "torture."

I wore my hat down over my eyes to avoid being recognized, and Sarah did the seeing for me. She took my arm and led me to the gate, where we waited until boarding. This was the last moment for her to back out, and I told her so. "You don't have to do this," I said.

"Do what?"

"Protect me like this."

Sarah stiffened. "Let's get one thing clear," she said as we boarded, "I'm not protecting you. No one can protect you. What I'm here for is to make it harder for anyone to interfere. To make sure everyone's on their best behavior."

"So you're my witness," I said.

She gave a slight wry smile. "Someone has to be the last person to ever see you alive. It might as well be me."

Though the three points where I'd thought we were most likely to get stopped were now behind us (check-in, passport control, and the gate), I didn't